UNIT 7.4 · LEVEL A1

Ability – could / couldn’t (past ability)

50 questions · 6 parts

Date: _____ Score: _____ / 50

When you finish, check the Answer Key at the end of this unit.

Part A · Multiple Choice (questions 1–10)

Circle the letter of the correct answer.

1 When I was five, I _____ swim.

a) can **b)** cans **c)** could **d)** coulds

2 She _____ read when she was three.

a) could **b)** can **c)** coulds **d)** canned

3 He _____ ride a bike when he was four. He was too young.

a) could **b)** can **c)** can't **d)** couldn't

4 _____ you speak English as a child?

a) Can **b)** Could **c)** Do **d)** Are

5 I couldn't _____ the answer.

a) knew **b)** know **c)** knows **d)** knowing

6 Which sentence is correct?

a) I could swam at six. **b)** I coulded swim at six.
c) I could to swim at six. **d)** I could swim at six.

7 Could they play the piano? — Yes, _____.

a) they could **b)** they can **c)** they were **d)** they do

8 Could you drive when you were ten? — No, _____.

a) I can't **b)** I don't **c)** I couldn't **d)** I wasn't

9 'Couldn't' is the short form of...

a) can not **b)** did not **c)** would not **d)** could not

10 When she was a baby, she _____ walk.

a) couldn't **b)** can't **c)** doesn't **d)** isn't

Part B · Fill in the Gaps (questions 11–20)

Write the missing word in each blank.

11 When I was six, I _____ swim.

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12 He _____ ride a bike at four.

13 They _____ speak English as children. (negative)

14 _____ you play the guitar when you were ten?

15 She couldn't _____ the book. It was too difficult.

16 Could he swim? — Yes, he _____.

17 Could you drive at fifteen? — No, I _____.

18 We _____ not hear the teacher.

19 When I was a child, I _____ run very fast.

20 _____ she speak French when she was ten?

Part C · Unscramble the Words (questions 21–28)

Put the words in the correct order to make a sentence. Write it on the line. Remember the capital letter and the full stop.

21 **could / swim / I / five / at**

_____

22 **couldn't / he / ride / a / bike**

_____

23 **could / you / swim / when / you / were / six**

_____

24 **she / read / could / three / at**

_____

25 **couldn't / they / English / speak**

_____

26 **could / the / hear / we / not / teacher**

_____

27 **baby / the / walk / couldn't**

_____

28 **piano / could / play / the / he**

_____

Part D · Choose and Complete (questions 29–35)

Choose the correct option and write it in the blank.

29 *Choose the correct word.*
When I was six, I _____ swim.
Options: **could** / **can** / **coulds**

30 *Choose the correct word.*
He _____ ride a bike at four.
Options: **couldn't** / **can't** / **cans**

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31 *Choose the correct word.*
_____ you swim as a child?
Options: **Could** / **Can** / **Do**

32 *Choose the correct word.*
She _____ read when she was three.
Options: **could** / **can** / **coulds**

33 *Choose the short answer.*
Could he swim? Yes, he _____ .
Options: **could** / **can** / **does**

34 *Choose the short answer.*
Could you drive at ten? No, I _____ .
Options: **couldn't** / **can't** / **don't**

35 *Choose the correct verb.*
They couldn't _____ English.
Options: **speak** / **spoke** / **speaks**

Part E · Matching (questions 36–40)

Match the items. Write the correct letter next to each number.

36 Match each sentence to its meaning.

1. I could swim. _____
2. I couldn't swim. _____
3. I can swim. _____
4. I can't swim. _____

A. I wasn't able to swim.
B. I am not able to swim now.
C. I was able to swim.
D. I am able to swim now.

37 Match each question to a short answer.

1. Could you swim at six? _____
2. Could he read at three? _____
3. Could they play the piano? _____
4. Could she drive at ten? _____

A. No, she couldn't.
B. Yes, I could.
C. No, he couldn't.
D. Yes, they could.

38 Match each beginning to its ending.

1. When I was six, _____
2. When he was a baby, _____
3. As a child, _____
4. At four, _____

A. they couldn't read.
B. she could draw well.
C. he couldn't walk.
D. I could swim.

39 Match each present form to its past form.

1. can _____
2. can't _____
3. can I? _____
4. can he? _____

A. couldn't
B. could I?
C. could he?
D. could

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40 Match each full form to its short form.

1. could not _____	**A.** didn't
2. cannot _____	**B.** couldn't
3. did not _____	**C.** wasn't
4. was not _____	**D.** can't

Part F · Find the Error (questions 41–50)

Each sentence has one mistake. Underline it and write the correct word.

41 I can swim when I was five. Correct word: _____

42 She could reads at three. Correct word: _____

43 He couldn't to swim. Correct word: _____

44 Can you swim when you were six? Correct word: _____

45 They coulded play the piano. Correct word: _____

46 I could not understood the teacher. Correct word: _____

47 Could she to dance? Correct word: _____

48 When he was a baby, he can't walk. Correct word: _____

49 She couldn't swam at six. Correct word: _____

50 We cans speak French as children. Correct word: _____

Your score

Count one point for each correct answer. Below 70%? Review the topic and try the unit again in a few days.

A	B	C	D	E	F	Total
____ / 10	____ / 10	____ / 8	____ / 7	____ / 5	____ / 10	____ **/ 50**

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Answer Key

Ability – could / couldn’t (past ability)

Part A · Multiple Choice

1	**c)** could	Past ability: could.
2	**a)** could	Past ability: could.
3	**d)** couldn't	He wasn't able to ride.
4	**b)** Could	Past ability question: Could...?
5	**b)** know	could/couldn't + base verb.
6	**d)** I could swim at six.	could + base verb.
7	**a)** they could	Short answer repeats 'could'.
8	**c)** I couldn't	Short answer repeats 'couldn't'.
9	**d)** could not	couldn't = could not.
10	**a)** couldn't	Babies aren't able to walk.

Part B · Fill in the Gaps

11	**could**	Past ability: could.
12	**could**	Past ability: could.
13	**couldn't** (or: could not)	Negative: couldn't.
14	**Could**	Past ability question.
15	**read**	could/couldn't + base verb.
16	**could**	Short answer repeats 'could'.
17	**couldn't** (or: could not)	Negative short answer.
18	**could**	could + not = could not.
19	**could**	Past ability: could.
20	**Could**	Past ability question.

Part C · Unscramble the Words

21	**I could swim at five.**	could + base verb.
22	**He couldn't ride a bike.**	couldn't + base verb.
23	**Could you swim when you were six?**	Could + subject + verb.
24	**She could read at three.**	could + base verb.
25	**They couldn't speak English.**	couldn't + base verb.
26	**We could not hear the teacher.**	could not + base verb.
27	**The baby couldn't walk.**	couldn't + base verb.
28	**He could play the piano.**	could + base verb.

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Part D · Choose and Complete

29	**could**	Past ability: could.
30	**couldn't**	Too young, so he couldn't.
31	**Could**	Past ability question.
32	**could**	Past ability: could.
33	**could**	Repeat 'could'.
34	**couldn't**	Repeat 'couldn't'.
35	**speak**	couldn't + base verb.

Part E · Matching

36	**1-C 2-A 3-D 4-B**	I could swim. – I was able to swim.; I couldn't swim. – I wasn't able to swim.; I can swim. – I am able to swim now.; I can't swim. – I am not able to swim now. Could = past; can = present.
37	**1-B 2-C 3-D 4-A**	Could you swim at six? – Yes, I could.; Could he read at three? – No, he couldn't.; Could they play the piano? – Yes, they could.; Could she drive at ten? – No, she couldn't. Repeat could/couldn't.
38	**1-D 2-C 3-B 4-A**	When I was six, – I could swim.; When he was a baby, – he couldn't walk.; As a child, – she could draw well.; At four, – they couldn't read. Choose the logical ending.
39	**1-D 2-A 3-B 4-C**	can – could; can't – couldn't; can I? – could I?; can he? – could he? Could is the past of can.
40	**1-B 2-D 3-A 4-C**	could not – couldn't; cannot – can't; did not – didn't; was not – wasn't Short forms join the verb and 'not'.

Part F · Find the Error

41	**could**	Past time needs 'could'.
42	**read**	After 'could' use the base verb.
43	**swim**	After 'couldn't' use the base verb.
44	**Could**	Past time needs 'Could'.
45	**could**	'Could' is already past.
46	**understand**	After 'could not' use the base verb.
47	**dance**	After 'could' use the base verb.
48	**couldn't** (or: could not)	Past time needs 'couldn't'.
49	**swim**	After 'couldn't' use the base verb.
50	**could**	Past ability needs 'could'.

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